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WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 14, 2026

Collins brings home bacon, but foes say aim higher

Democrats call for her to widen scope beyond Maine

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

PRESQUE ISLE, Maine — Passengers who take JetBlue's daily flight from this northern Maine town to Logan Airport quickly understand why Presque Isle International Airport is getting an upgrade.

The terminal, dating to the 1950s, is the air travel equivalent of a one-room schoolhouse. Check-in consists of a desk that is mere feet from the lone TSA screening lane, which leads to a waiting area crammed with seats in a space the size of a living room. Delays are even more uncomfortable here: There are no restrooms after security.

But greeting passengers in a video on TV screens nearly everywhere they look is the face of the person who helped secure critical funds for the sleek, spacious new terminal under construction next door: Republican Senator Susan Collins.

For Collins, the power to direct federal money to projects in Maine has been a defining tool over her 30-year Senate career. It's perhaps been the senator's preferred way to demonstrate her effectiveness and her connection to the state — and also make the case for reelection.

Now the chair of the powerful Senate Appropriations Committee that oversees the Congressionally Directed Spending, also known as the "earmark" process, Collins is at the peak of her influence precisely as she faces what could be her most challenging campaign yet.

In her first debate with Democratic challenger Troy Jackson last Tuesday, Collins mentioned her leadership of the panel and her steering of federal cash to Maine — nearly $1.5 billion in earmarks since 2021 — within seconds of her opening statement.

COLLINS, Page A6

HELEN BRANSWELL, 69

The reporter to turn to when COVID struck

By Andrew Joseph
STAT

Helen Branswell, a renowned infectious disease reporter who earned the respect of experts and public health officials around the world with her accessible, prescient dispatches on scourges from influenza to polio and Ebola to COVID-19, becoming a vital source of information for the public during the most chaotic of times, died Tuesday at age 69.

The cause was complications from cancer, said her sister, Brenda Branswell.

Ms. Branswell, a longtime reporter at the Canadian Press, joined Stat at its founding in 2015, working out of the Boston headquarters before returning home to Canada last year to be closer to family in Ottawa.

"Throughout her career, Helen demonstrated an unwavering commitment to evidence, science, and truth, helping the public understand some of the most complex and consequential health challenges of our time," Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, the director-general of the World Health Organization, wrote in an email. "At a moment when

BRANSWELL, Page A6

Nursing home chain targeted

State regulators move to revoke licenses of RegalCare after report of poor care

By Kay Lazar and Gordon Russell
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts regulators on Tuesday moved to revoke all of the nursing home licenses held by RegalCare, a New Jersey-based company that went on a buying spree in the state after the pandemic, slashed costs, and gutted the quality of care at many of its 12 homes.

Spotlight FOLLOW-UP

The action comes directly on the heels of reporting by The Boston Globe Spotlight Team that chronicled the stark changes that occurred after Eli Mirlis, RegalCare's chief executive, purchased the facilities and made steep cuts to nursing and other services while steering funds to related businesses he owns.

Despite the move to revoke its licenses, RegalCare won't immediately lose control of its homes, according to officials from the state Department of Public Health. For the time being, they'll be subject to enhanced monitoring from DPH.

A company representative indicated in a statement late Tuesday that RegalCare will challenge the planned license revocations, which would trigger a hearing process at which the state will have to make its case for taking Mirlis's licenses away. Regulators said that if they are successful, Mirlis will be barred from operating nursing homes in Massachusetts for the next decade.

"Families trust nursing homes to care for their loved ones, and every resident deserves safe, compassionate, high-quality care that respects their dignity," Dr. Robbie Goldstein, commissioner of the department, said in a statement to the Globe. "The Department of Public Health takes seriously its responsibility to uphold these standards and protect the well-being of every resident."

Some of those who had relatives who suffered at RegalCare homes welcomed the news.

"I'm happy the state's doing something," said Theresa Walsh Jr., whose mother died a few weeks after receiving two different types of antidepressants at the Holyoke facility, when she normally only received one. "It was very frustrating to watch the article and see stuff on

NURSING HOMES, Page A7



MATTHEW J. LEE/GLOBE STAFF

"I worked my butt off to help my community only to learn that I'm on the hook for it," Dr. Zachary Kramer said.

For former Steward clinicians, the nightmare never ends

With in-house insurer broke, many are left to fight malpractice suits on their own

By Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

Dr. Peter Rees, a longtime primary care doctor in Haverhill, is 82. He'd hoped to be retired by now, spending more time with his wife, kids, and dozen grandchildren.

But he has a huge financial threat hanging over him: a malpractice lawsuit dating from when he worked for Steward Health Care.

The bankrupt hospital chain's in-house malpractice insurer, TRACO, is effectively broke, leaving Rees with tens of thousands of dollars in legal fees and the possibility of a multimillion-dollar judgment that could cost him everything, including his home.

He is among the scores of former Steward doctors, nurses, and other clinicians who face the prospect of financial ruin over the implosion of TRACO, which was looted by Steward executives as the for-profit chain spiraled downward. Some medical workers are raiding savings and retirement accounts to pay for their own insurance; still others are holding the bag for hefty legal settlements TRACO had agreed to pay but failed to honor.

"They know you can't get money from a stone, so the [malpractice] attorneys assume that rich old doctors have money and say, 'Let's go after them,' " said Rees, whose case is set for trial in February. "What do I do? Work until I collapse and die?"

In dozens of interviews and email exchanges, former front-line Steward clinicians describe a pervasive feeling of abandonment.

Two years ago, top Massachusetts officials lionized Steward medical workers as "true heroes" for delivering babies, performing surgeries, and holding emergency departments together through chaos. But now,

STEWARD, Page A7

So quick to criticize, we dropped ball on Maye

DAN SHAUGHNESSY

COMMENTARY

The overreaction was over the top. Even for Boston.

A pair of Super Bowl quarterbacks went on the air and said it was time to bench Drake Maye. My inbox was flooded with folks comparing The Drake to Mac Jones and Tony Eason. Readers were calling for Tommy Cutlets.

Truly.

The speed with which so many folks gave up on Maye was stunning.

Six picks, one lost fumble, and a 1-2 record after a 35-6 beatdown in Jacksonville had many giving up on a 24-year-old quarterback who just a few months ago won a conference championship game in the Denver snow to take the Patriots to a Super Bowl and was runner-up in voting for the NFL's Most Valuable Player award.

Maye rebounded with strong games in

SHAUGHNESSY, Page C2



MATTHEW J. LEE/GLOBE STAFF

Drake Maye had a smile on his face Sunday after the Patriots beat the Raiders.

Pope Leo XIV underwent surgery that confirmed he has lung cancer, and doctors removed the lower lobe of the 71-year-old's right lung, the Vatican said. **A3.**

Websites and apps for grocery chains Stop & Shop, Hannaford, and Giant Food were offline after their parent company experienced a cyber incident. **B5.**

US Ambassador to Greece Kimberly Guilfoyle resigned as she faced mounting accusations of improper and possibly illegal conduct. **A2.**

Payton Pritchard agreed to a two-year, $44.2 million contract extension with the Celtics, a source confirmed. **C1.**

You can smell apple cider doughnuts before you even pull into an orchard, and even the bad ones taste good. **G1.**

Sun of a gun

Wednesday: Very warm. High 76-81. Low 51-56.

Thursday: Back to normal. High 60-65. Low 47-52.

Sunrise: 6:56 Sunset: 6:04

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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